

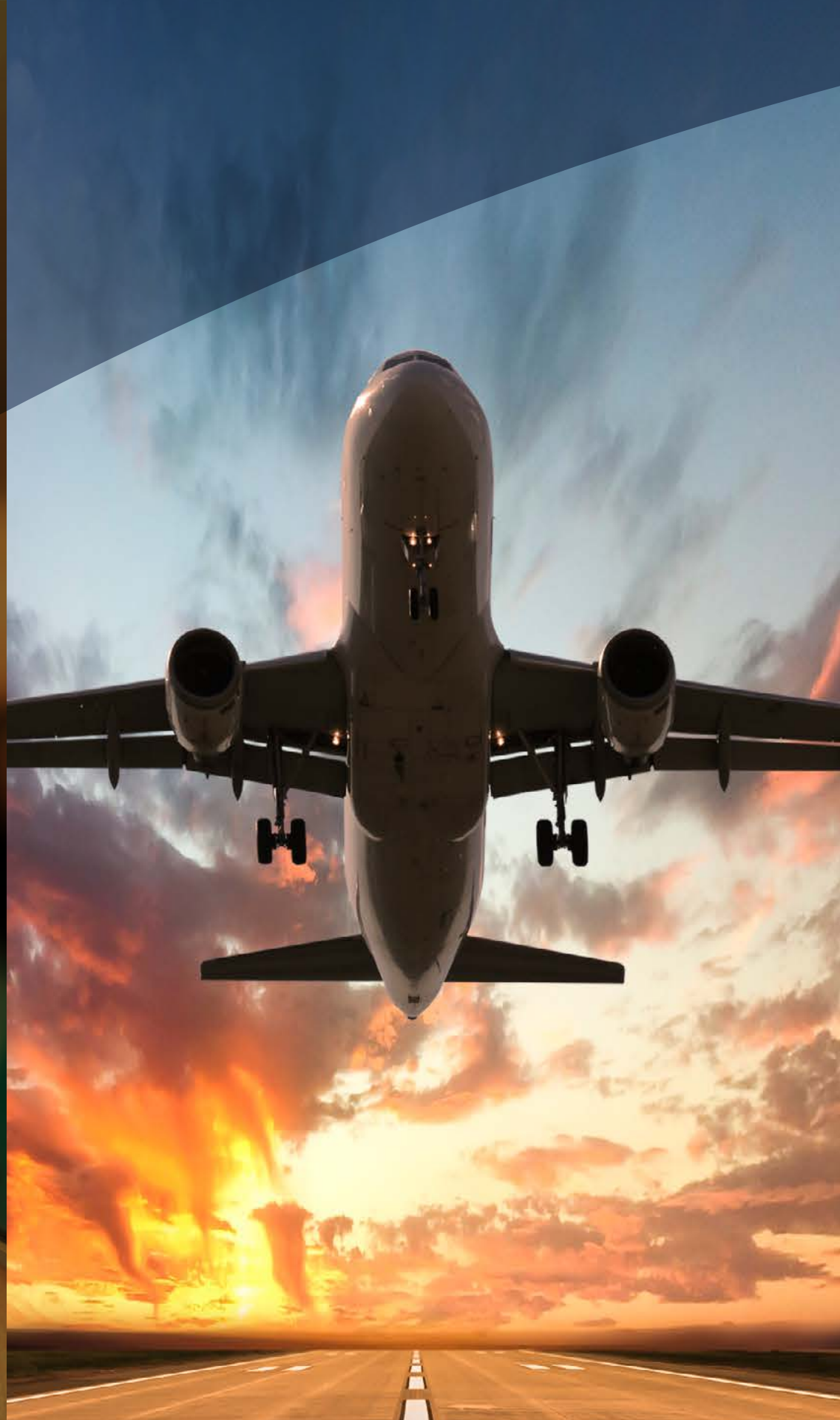
Image Style Guide

Our guidelines for
on-brand photography.

2025



Houlihan Lokey



A Path to Authenticity

Images are one of the most important drivers of interest and engagement. They are also key in differentiating us from our competition and shaping the views of our audience. They can even impact how we communicate business value.

Fun Facts:

- 65% of people are visual thinkers. –Social Science Research Network
- Visual content performs 4.4 times better than text-based content. –Chute and Digiday Study
- Businesses get 60% more inquiries or actions when images appear. –Marketer, Neil Patel
- 90% of information that comes to the brain is visual. –Hyerle
- Presentations with visual aides are 43% more persuasive. –Marketer, Neil Patel
- Images get 94% more views than those without. –Marketer, Jeff Bullas

When we represent people in imagery, anytime we can select photos that look natural and have an editorial feel versus a commercial “stock look,” we connect in more intimate ways and give people an authentic view of who we are and what they might expect when working with us.



Authenticity?

When we express authenticity, we use images that look natural and real instead of posed or contrived.

Unfortunately, stock image archives are fraught with cheesy off-putting images that can detract from the content they're supposed to be supporting.

We've all seen plenty of pictures of smiling employees, high-fiving or shaking hands in staged settings. Or the infamous “busy fingers on keyboard” shot typically used as a last resort when a better image can't be found. These types of images are overused, emotionally shallow, and, due to their generic and clichéd nature, are often an easy option to select.



Visual Guidelines

Finding the right stock image can be a challenge. We've assembled the following guidelines to inspire and help you with on-brand photo selection. Our goal is to represent a range of imagery that feels authentic and consistent in look, tone, and feel.

Pro Tip:

- Use crisp, clear, and vivid high-resolution images.
- Choose images that emotionally strike you.
- Use basic photography guidelines, such as light, composition, and depth of field.

Consider images that align to your message and our reputation:

Trustworthy
Inspired
Confident

Passionate
Informative
Credible



EVOCATIVE IMAGERY



CRISP, CLEAR, AND VIVID HIGH-RESOLUTION



AUTHENTIC IMAGERY



DYNAMIC IMAGERY

Poor Image Selection

Presentation is everything. We know that making a good first impression is important, especially in business. Audiences will create an impression of our company based on a variety of factors and touch points. Call it superficial, but small details matter.

Pro Tip:

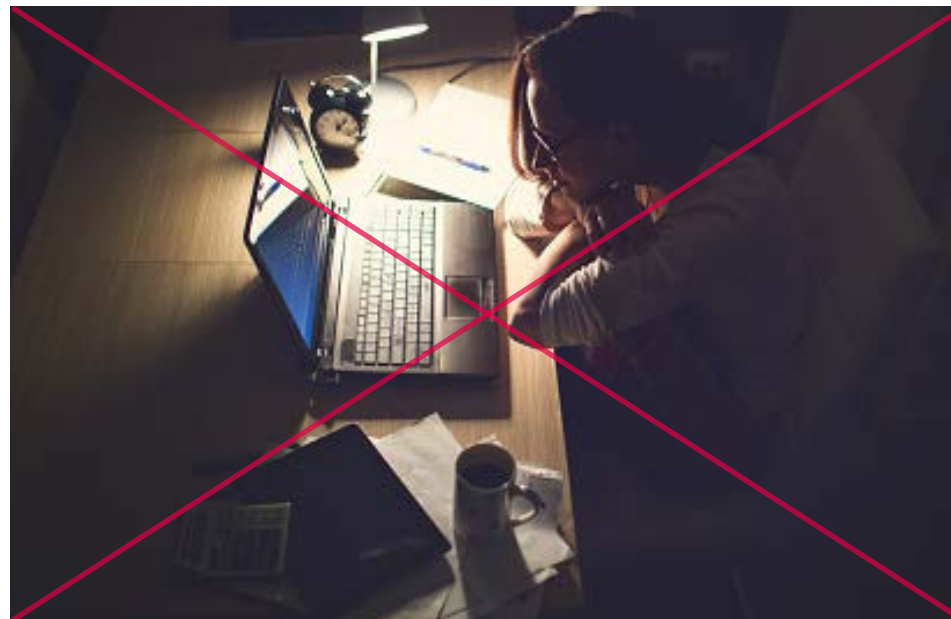
- Avoid pixelated, blurred, or stretched images.
- Search for images that aren't contrived, badly lit, or flat.
- Use exact dimensions to avoid the image stretching or pixelating.
- For an editorial look, choose images where the subject person is not making direct eye contact with the camera. Editorial style images are more interesting and tell a better story.



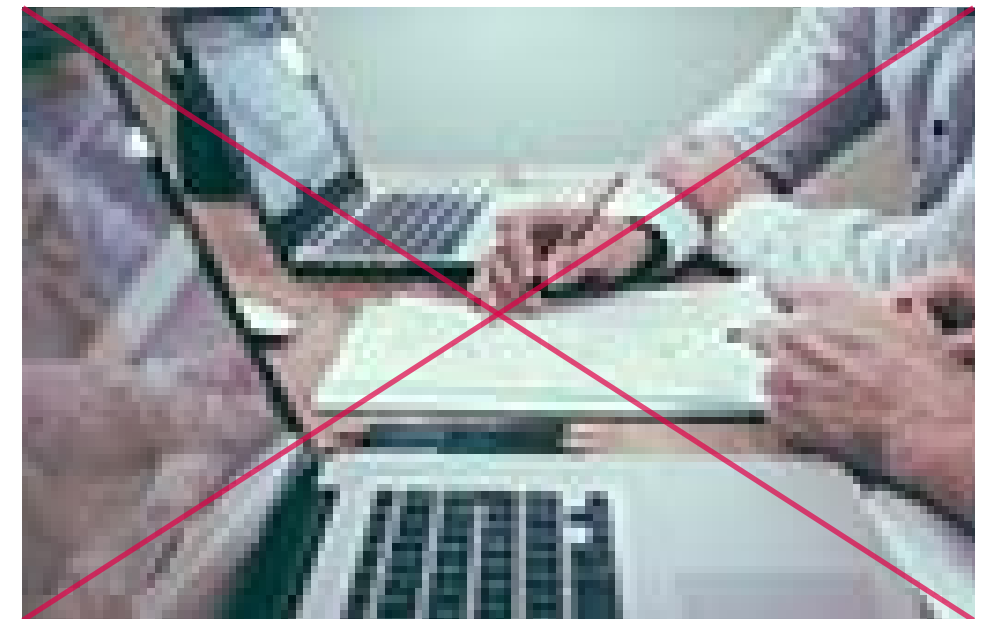
DISTORTED/STRETCHED IMAGERY



CONTRIVED IMAGERY



POORLY LIT IMAGERY

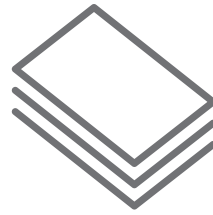


PIXELATED IMAGERY

Technical Guidelines

Most of us don't have the in-depth technical knowledge of a production artist or programmer, but here are a few basics to guide you so that your images preserve quality for the intended medium.

Contact HL Creative Services for in-depth technical guidelines.



Print

- All greyscales and color images must be set at a minimum of 300 dpi.
- For a clean print image, logos and text should be set as vectors and not as pixel images.
- Image files, which are set to RGB, must be converted to CMYK before release for production.



PDF

- PDFs that aren't optimized can kill file sharing and viewing due to their large file size.
- Open the original PDF in Acrobat Pro: File > Save as Other > Optimized PDF.
- You can also edit settings in the Adobe PDF optimizer.
- If you don't have Acrobat Pro, you can optimize by using a free online optimizer, such as smallpdf.com/compress-pdf



Web

Choose the right file type:

- JPEG—Preferred for photography; adjust the resolution level for a good balance of quality and optimized file size.
- PNG—Best choice for storing line drawings, text, and iconic graphics at a small file size.
- GIF—Only uses 256 colors; it's the best choice for animated images.

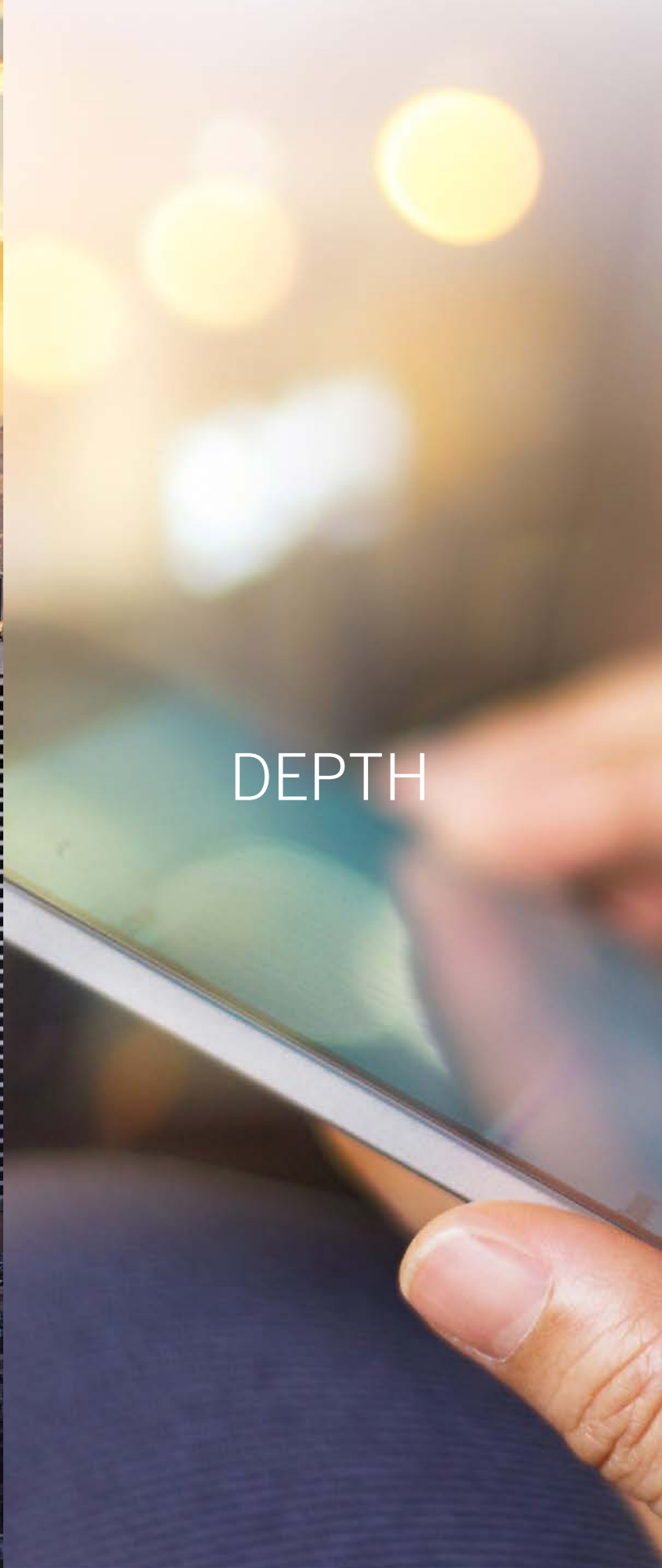


Email

- Always convert to RGB (never CMYK).
- Photoshop for JPG and PNG optimization: File > Export > Web (Legacy).
- For Graphics: PNG 8-bit. Most files < 10-20k, large images < 80-120k.



LIGHT



DEPTH



COMPOSITION



DIVERSITY

Light

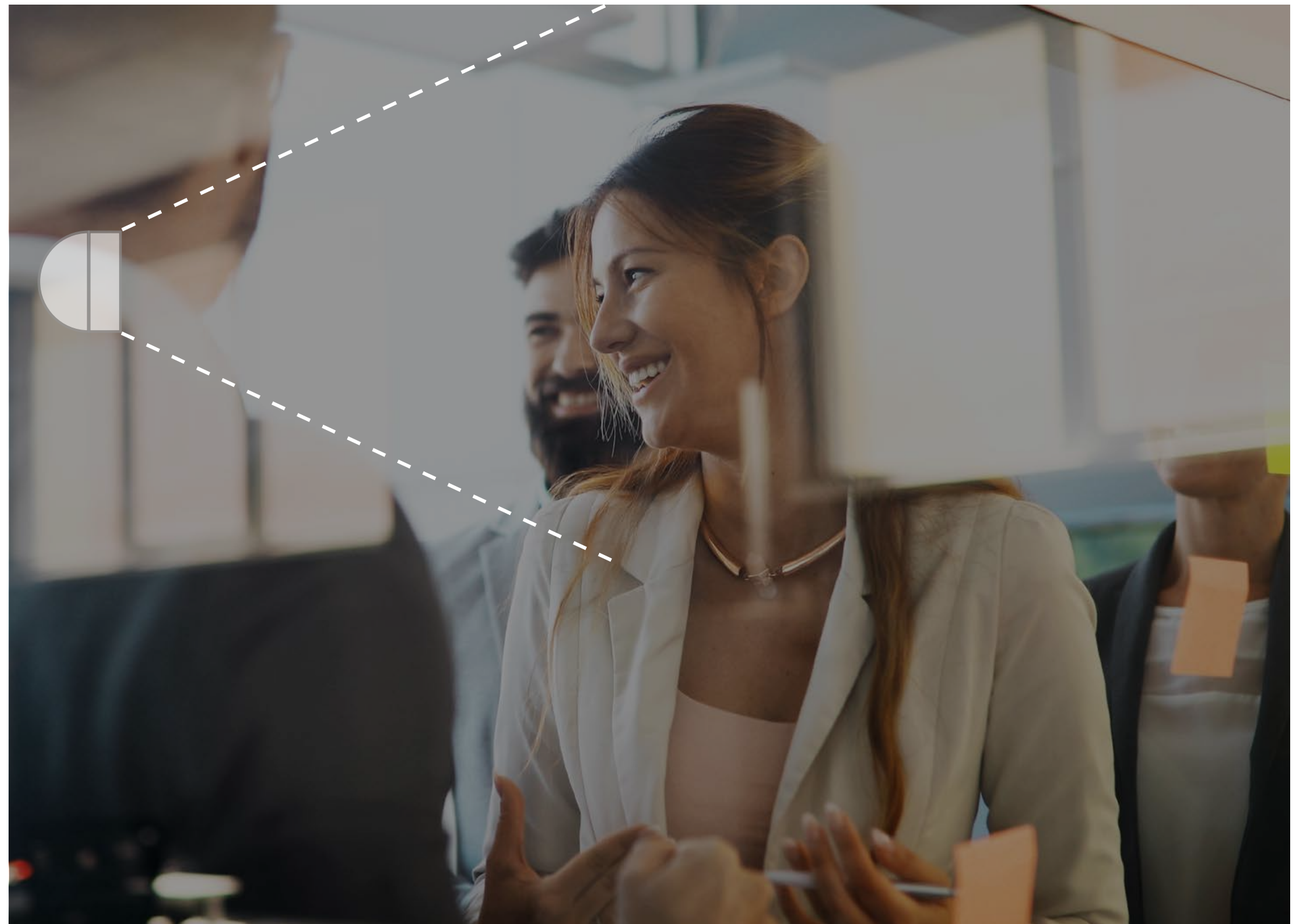
When it comes to evoking emotions, lighting is the most powerful tool. Photographers paint with it.

Pro Tip:

Choose shots rich in light and with interesting contrasts and shadows. Capture the energy of an idea or scene with an image that has interesting and thoughtful lighting.

Light Source

Light is more dramatic when its source resides at an angle. This provides for interesting shadows and strong textures.



Depth

An image with depth allows us to convey multiple layers of messaging and helps draw a viewer into the scene.

Pro Tip:

Look for different elements in the picture and take advantage of the specific focus and the depth of field to dictate what is most important in the picture.

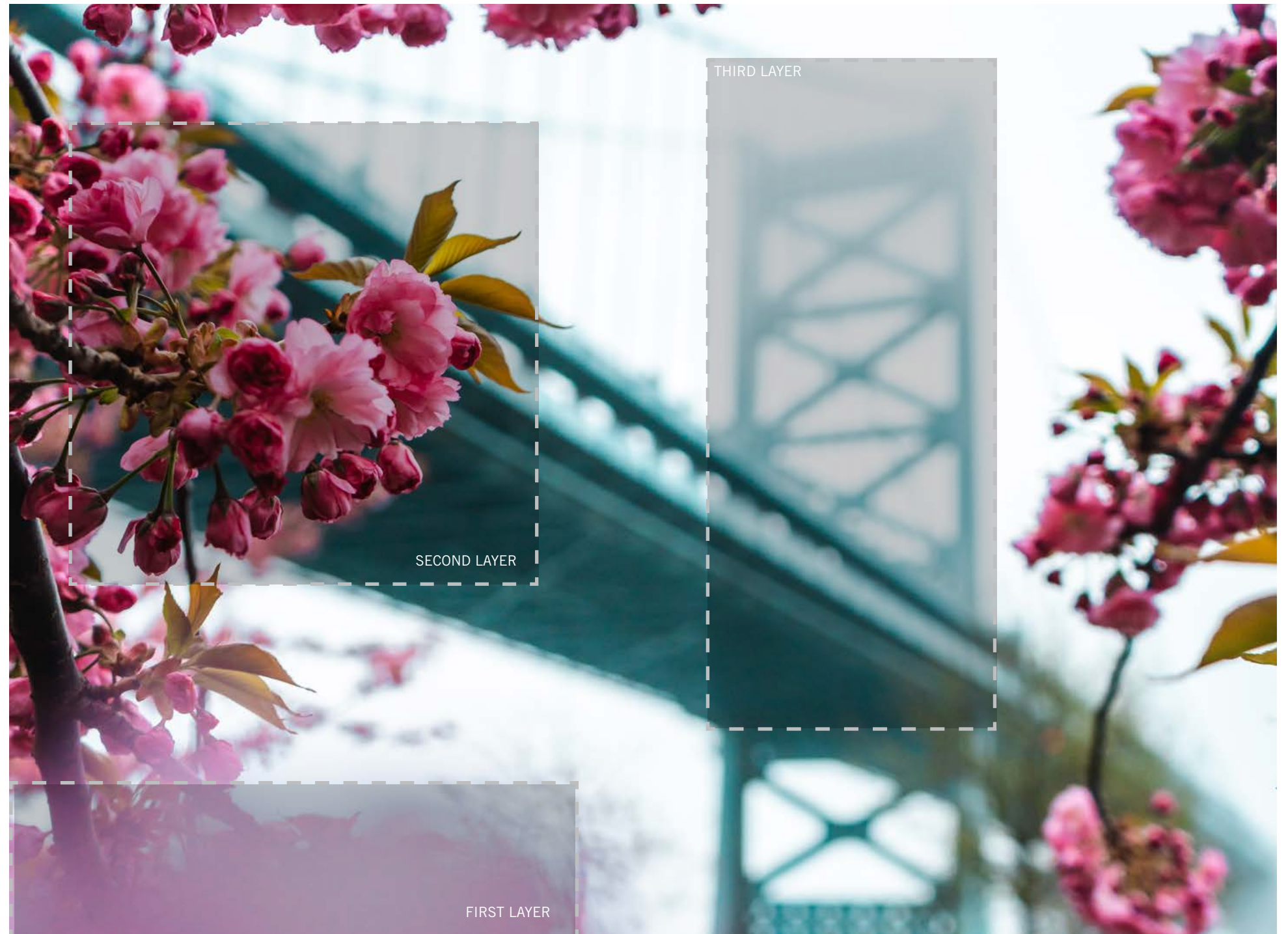


Depth of Field With Layers

Depth of field is one of the most important techniques we can utilize to simulate a three-dimensional reality. It refers to the nearest and farthest points in a photo, where the main subject appears in sharp focus.

Pro Tip:

For a richer 3D effect, use images where the sharp focus is between a blurred foreground and background.



Composition

In photography, most viewers expect to see an interesting subject. If the viewer has to search for the main subject in an image, they'll stop looking. Good composition helps us frame our main subject in a picture, allowing us to deliver a more interesting and memorable message.



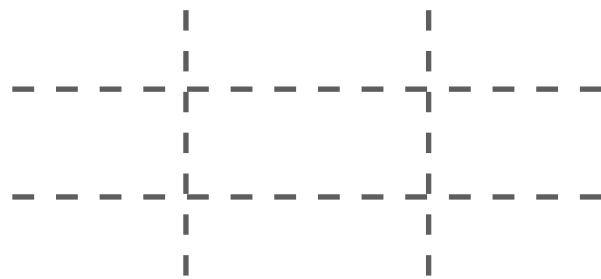
Composition Principles

Our eyes tend to follow strong lines, so use lines to lead a viewer's eyes to the subject. Strong lines create mood in pictures: vertical and horizontal lines are static; strong diagonal lines are dynamic.

VANISHING LEADING LINES



RULE OF THIRDS GRID



CONICAL LEADING LINES

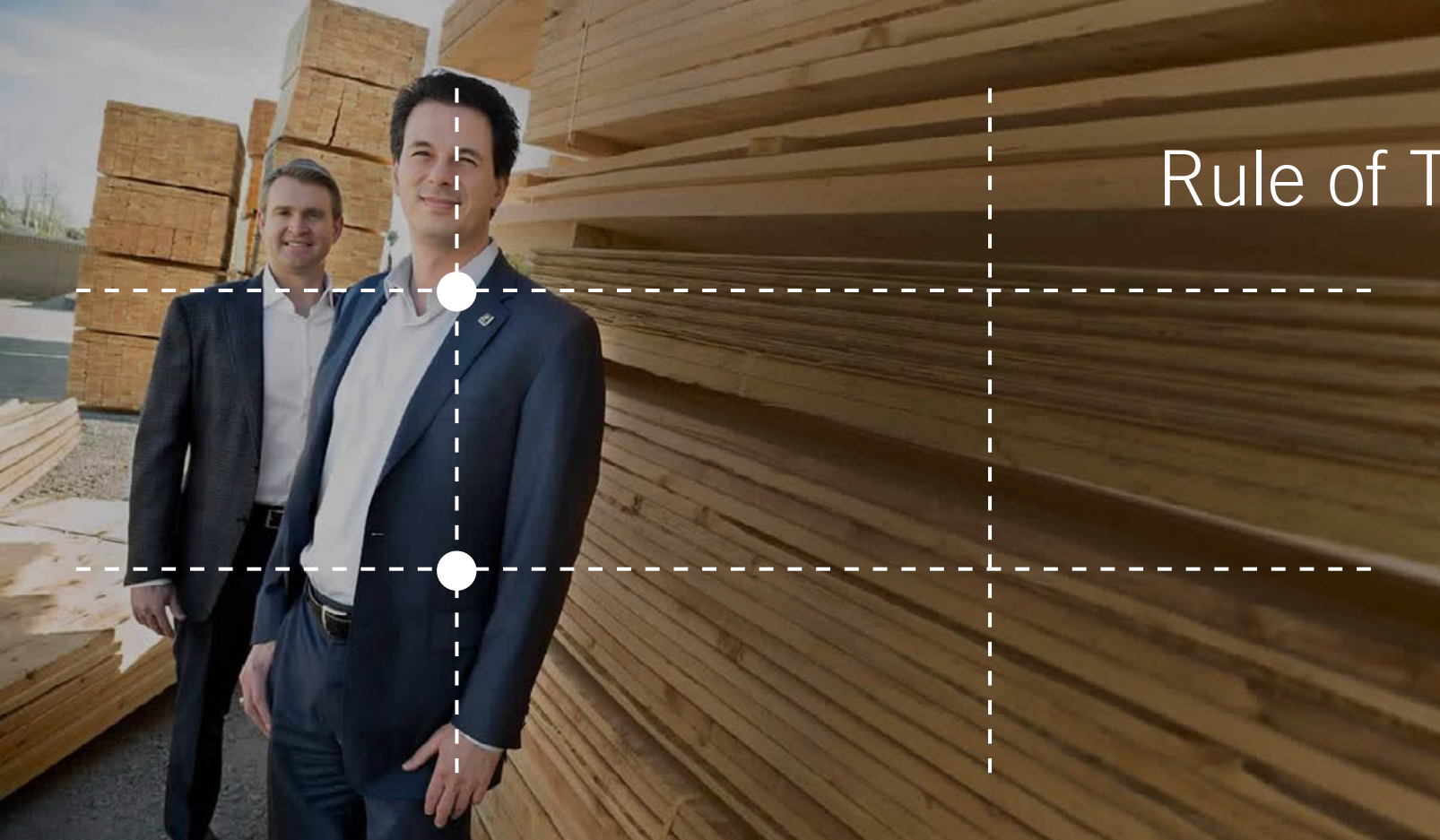


Vanishing Leading Lines



Conical Leading Lines





Diversity

A company is as unique as the individuals working within it. We live in a complex, interconnected world where diversity, shaped by our global presence, forms the fabric of our unique work culture.

To be authentic, our imagery should strive to capture diversity across a range of individuals in age, gender, race, and religion.



A Human Portrait

When we decided to refresh the visual criteria for HL.com, our goal was to humanize the experience for visitors and connect them to what truly sets us apart—our employees. It's our greatest asset, so why not use actual images of Houlihan Lokey employees when possible.

How we present our people speaks volumes to our personality. Competitors can copy many things about us, but the one thing they cannot copy is our human capital and culture.



Metaphorical Imagery

Metaphors can be powerful in creating vivid images in the mind and distinguishing us from the typical boring financial images. Metaphors engage the right brain. They bypass rationality and lower defenses to pitches, opinion pieces, and white papers. Metaphors demonstrate our cleverness and deliver the unexpected.

Architecture/Buildings

- Power, strength, stability

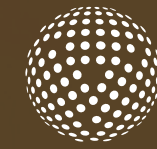
Bridges/Overpasses

- Transformation, connectedness, new possibilities

Nature

- Rivers: continuous change, process flow
- Pathways: guidance, showing the way
- Trees: majestic, roots, history, growth, longevity
- Skies/Sunsets: endless possibilities, higher order, new beginnings





Houlihan Lokey

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For questions and requests, please contact

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